

GRIT AND GLAMOUR

The brave Dutt daughters offer an intimate account of growing up in the shade of two Bollywood icons



MR AND MRS DUTT: MEMORIES OF OUR PARENTS
by NAMRATA DUTT KUMAR AND PRIYA DUTT
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■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Sometimes the greatest love stories are between parents and children. No, no, please, it's not what you think. This is the purest kind of love that sees two daughters giving up almost a whole year of college and school to sit at their mother's bedside in cold, cold New York, first waiting for her to come out of coma, and then willing her to live. It's the kind of devotion that sees a father selling his beloved home to pay for his son's legal fees. It's the kind of passion that sees an enormous star, at the height of her fame, with 46 films behind her, moving from a grand, four-bedroom apartment in Marine Drive, into a one-room flat to share it with a young man, with just two films to his credit, his mother, his sister, her children, a domestic and a dog.

Mr and Mrs Dutt: Memories of Our Parents is a memoir both profound and poignant. It is a story of a family at once ordinary and amazing. A family that sweeps away all the idols in the house into the sea once it loses its mother. A family that has to live with the shock of being branded terrorists after having worshipped at the feet of honesty all its life. A family that loses one battle with cancer only to see it repeated in the death of an adored daughter-in-law. Namrata Dutt Kumar and Priya Dutt have written an account most moving in its simplicity and raw in its pain. Whether it is at the burial, when they bathe their mother's body with their father, rejecting the help of



THE PROUD FAMILY:
(Clockwise from top)
Nargis with Sunil; the
'lioness with her cubs';
Sunil with Priya and
Namrata; Sanjay in
the US de-addiction
centre; Nargis' letter
to her son; Nehru with
Nargis and Sunil

the women of the family, or the frisking they are submitted to while delivering meals to their brother in prison, the two daughters—familiar to 24x7 television viewers as the women who stand stoic in the background every time Sanjay Dutt goes to prison—emerge with steel in their spines and iron in their souls. Not Nargis's daughters for nothing, they are mini earth mothers, keeping their father afloat as his wife dies, a brother out of de-addic-

Darling Son Sanjay -

After I left you in school I was terribly disturbed - You were crying and I was feeling very bad - Sanjay - I know my boy that you must be missing home and me, we miss you too. The house is empty without you - but Sanjay you must try to understand that it is for your own good - You will be a good student - and study well over there - Your results there are much better than what they were in Bombay. Now you have promised to do even better and I promise I will come to see you every month - You know you are our only son and we have great hopes on you - You must study hard and become a big man so that you can look after us in our old age.